

THEME 4

On the Interpretation of Art Works

Our previous Theme considered the nature of art and its value. However, often underlying our assessments of art are questions of interpretation. What does a work of art actually *mean*? Should we look for meaning at all? And where and how should we look for it? Can works of art carry moral meanings? These questions are our focus in this Theme.

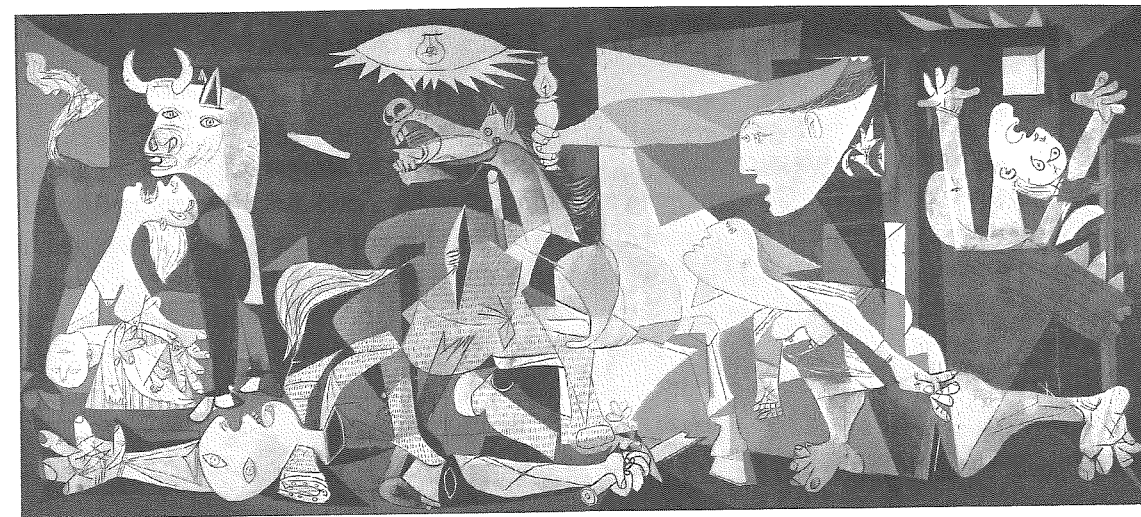
As with our previous Theme, it will be useful to draw on any experiences of art available to you. The term 'art' covers a multitude of forms, including novels, poetry, plays, songs, all styles of music, dance, sculpture, installation, film, photography, graphic design, architecture, painting, drawing and animation. Reflecting on your past and present encounters with these artforms, as well as organising new experiences of art – such as a visit to a local gallery – will enhance your philosophical exploration of how we find meaning in art.

Introductory Activities

DO

Working by yourself, study the following image and write your own answers to the questions beneath.

1. Describe what you see in this painting.
2. What do you think the artist is trying to depict in this painting?
3. Does this painting have a particular point of view? Could it be said that this painting contains an argument? Why or why not?
4. Do you recognise this painting and its artist? How does that recognition – or lack thereof – affect the way you approach the image?



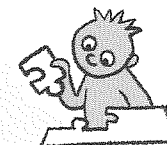
Pablo Picasso's *Guernica* (1937) is among the most famous paintings of the twentieth century. Picasso created it during the Spanish Civil War in response to the bombings of a small town named Guernica in northern Spain.

The painting is generally interpreted as a depiction of the suffering which war inflicts upon innocent civilians. It has become world famous as an indictment of war.

But is this the only interpretation possible? And is it the only correct interpretation?

DO

Survey your class to find out which students were acquainted with *Guernica* prior to the exercise above, and which students were encountering it for the first time. How did the 'naïve' interpretations compare with the 'informed' ones?



If you are encountering *Guernica* for the first time, what do you see? Do you see images of war, terror, violence, chaos and suffering? Do you read a political message? If you see something quite different from the orthodox interpretation of this work, who is to say yours is not a valid interpretation, an equally important way of finding meaning in this artwork?

And what is the status of the view communicated by Picasso's painting? Is this just as powerful an indictment of war as a philosophical argument for pacifism? Or can it be said that Picasso has produced a philosophical argument – and if so, what are its premises and conclusions?

THINK

Can art be philosophy? Can it be said to produce arguments? Can you think of other relevant examples to draw into this discussion?

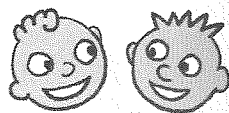


Arbiters of Meaning: Author, Text or Audience?

Intentionalism

Picasso himself stated that his purpose in painting *Guernica* was to bring international attention to the bombing of civilians by Germans, who were supporting General Franco during the Spanish Civil War. Picasso was inspired by an eyewitness report by journalist George Steer, published in both the *New York Times* and *The Times*, two days after the bombings. Within six weeks, Picasso, working in Paris, had completed the massive mural-size canvas, and the painting spent the next several years touring the globe and gaining the exposure its artist hoped for. Picasso expressed his wish that *Guernica* should not come to Spain, his country of origin, until freedom and democracy had been re-established. It arrived in Spain in 1981 and now hangs in the Reina Sofia Gallery, Madrid.

For those who follow the **intentionalist** theory of art, this information about *Guernica*'s context and Picasso's intentions is crucial if we are to make an accurate interpretation of the artwork. According to the intentionalist theory, if we can obtain knowledge about the artist, his life, his intentions and state of mind when he created a particular work of art, we will have the definitive and authoritative account of what the work is meant to convey. We can then judge how successfully it achieves these aims. In other words, intentionalism says that a work of art means whatever its creator intended it to mean.



DISCUSS

1. In your opinion, how relevant to the *meaning* of the painting *Guernica* is contextual information?
2. Does knowledge of Picasso's stated intentions in painting *Guernica* enhance your appreciation for the work?
3. Does knowledge of Picasso's intentions in painting *Guernica* make alternative interpretations *wrong*?
4. In what ways might the intentionalist theory be problematic? Brainstorm a list of responses on your classroom whiteboard.

KANT, THE ROMANTICS AND THE AUTHORITY OF GENIUS

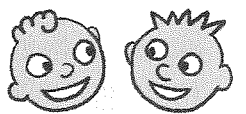
One of the defining features of the so-called Romantic era – spanning the nineteenth century – was the elevation of the artist to the status of heroic and inspired *genius*. This was the word used by Immanuel Kant (Famous Philosopher File p.111) in his *Critique of Judgment* (1790). Kant argued that because art does not follow rules, artistic talent cannot be taught. It must therefore be innate and intuitive. The artist of Romantic imagination was a driven by special sensitivity and insight. The implication of this view for interpreting works of art is that the artist has unique authority, which should be revered.

You will no doubt be familiar with this idea, as it still resonates today. R.G.Collingwood (Famous Philosopher File p.526), whose work we read about in the previous Theme, was clearly influenced by Romanticism. In arguing that the worth of a piece of art lies in its expression of the artist's emotion, Collingwood implies that (a) the artist has an emotional intensity which the rest of us would benefit from sharing in, and (b) to understand or value the artwork, we need some insight into the state of mind of the artist (see Text Study, p.526).



WRITE

1. What is the 'Romantic' view of the artist? Describe it in a couple of sentences.
2. Reflect upon the way you regard creators in various artforms (for example, your favourite authors, actors, directors, musicians and so on). To what extent do you subscribe to this Romantic view? Why?

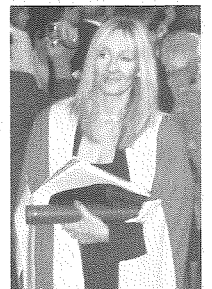


DISCUSS

When the news broke in 2007 it caused a sensation through news media worldwide. After reading from *Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows* at New York's Carnegie Hall, author J. K. Rowling took questions from her audience of 1,600 students. In response to a query about Dumbledore's love life, Rowling replied, 'My truthful answer to you... I always thought of Dumbledore as gay.'*

Rowling's stunned audience took its time to recover from the bombshell before bursting into applause. Within minutes, international headlines screamed, 'Dumbledore is gay!'

Rowling explained to her Carnegie Hall audience that when reading a film script for one of her books, she had to reject a newly created Dumbledore back-story about a supposed past crush on a girl, scribbling 'Dumbledore is gay!' in the margin.



How are we to take this new data about a fictional character? Does Rowling, as author, have unique authority to banish alternative interpretations with a 'fact' about her creation, Dumbledore?

1. Is it a 'fact' that Dumbledore is gay if J.K.Rowling says he is?
2. Should interpretations of the Harry Potter books which differ from Rowling's be considered wrong?

* 'Dumbledore was gay, JK tells amazed fans' by David Smith, Sunday 21st October 2007, <http://www.theguardian.com/uk/2007/oct/21/film.books> (accessed September 1st, 2013)

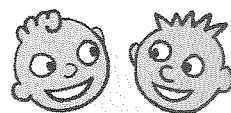
Anti-Intentionalism

T.S.ELIOT, NEW CRITICISM AND THE 'INTENTIONAL FALLACY'

In a reaction against the subjectivism of the Romantics, the poet T.S.Eliot published a landmark work of literary criticism in 1919. His essay, 'Tradition and the Individual Talent', rejects the Romantic obsession with the character of the artist, and argues that the only authority on the meaning of a poem is the poem itself. The artist 'surrenders' his work after its creation, according to Eliot. Eliot's arguments inspired the so-called **New Criticism** movement of the 1920s and 30s, which regarded works of art as **autonomous** entities and emphasised close analysis of their internal rather than external features.

Reflecting the New Criticism in many ways, literary theorist W.K. Wimsatt and philosopher Monroe Beardsley published 'The Intentional Fallacy' in 1954, arguing – to quote the essay's final sentence – that 'critical inquiries are not settled by consulting the oracle' – that is, the artist. There is always a problem of access when it comes to an artist's intention, they contend. We can never be fully sure of an artist's complete state of mind when they created a work of art. An artist's ideas about her work should thus be considered just one valid interpretation among many. According to Wimsatt and Beardsley, when assessing the validity of competing interpretations we should ask questions such as which one best matches the evidence in the text, and which interpretation allows for the richest and most coherent reading.

On this way of viewing an artwork, its meaning belongs neither to the author nor the reader, but to the art, in itself, separate from its context. The art yields a fixed set of possible meanings, regardless of when it is read or by whom.



DISCUSS

1. One of Wimsatt and Beardsley's objections to intentionalism is that we cannot always be sure of an artist's intention. Is this a strong objection? Is there any way it can be overcome to save the intentionalist view?
2. Should we completely reject contextual information when looking for meaning in works of art? Why or why not?

TEXT STUDY: William K. Wimsatt and Monroe C. Beardsley, 'The Intentional Fallacy' (1946)



[see Useful Resources]

READ Section I of the essay.

1. What set of assumptions make up what Wimsatt and Beardsley call 'the intentional fallacy'?

DON'T WORRY ABOUT THIS BOX, LARA! What are some implications of the view that 'the intention of the author is neither available nor desirable as a standard for judging the success of a work of literary art'?

What do Wimsatt and Beardsley argue is the difficulty of inferring an author's intention through studying his/her work?

4. What does it mean to say that 'a poem should not mean but be'?
5. According to Wimsatt and Beardsley, can an author's original intention be revised? Why or why not?
6. In what sense may a poem/work of art be said to be a public document?
7. Might there be other justifications for studying the social and publication context of a text in addition to a concern with its author's intentions?
8. Does this essay provide valuable insights on the interpretation of artworks? Which of its points do you find persuasive and why? On what grounds might this essay be criticised?

ROLAND BARTHES: DEATH OF THE AUTHOR

Like Wimsatt and Beardsley, Roland Barthes' *Death of the Author* (1967) rejects the Romantic view of the artist as the supreme arbiter of meaning. But Barthes (1915-1980) went further still, denying the author any role in the ongoing interpretation of her work. According to Barthes, the author is 'dead' once her creation is released to the public. To think otherwise is to 'close' the work. For Barthes, the text is 'open' and perpetually recreated every time it is read. It is 'played' like a game or a musical instrument, with readers as active participants in the production of meaning. The meanings of a text (or work of art) lie in the multiplicity of expanding interpretations made by its readers.

Barthes' ideas foreshadowed the themes of **post-structuralism**. Michael Foucault's 'What is an Author?' (1969) further diminishes the status of the author. Like Barthes, Foucault (Famous Philosopher File p.543) rejects views such as those of Eliot, the New Critics and Wimsatt and Beardsley, who hold the text up as the authority of its own meaning. Rather, for Foucault and post-structuralist reading, the *reader* is the authority. Indeed, each act of reading creates a new work, because, as the post-structuralist argues, every reader brings a vast web of inter-relating meanings and associations to each encounter they have with a text or artwork. On this account, Rowling's reading of Dumbledore has no special status whatever, and each reader is free to 'play' with the stories of Harry Potter as they will. Each time you read Harry Potter you will interact with it in a new way. Foucault argues that it is only because we fear the vast proliferation of alternative meanings that we try to fix meaning to a single authorial source.